

THE TEMPTATION OF CHRIST

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Matthew 4:1-11 (NKJV) *“Then Jesus was led up by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil. ² And when He had fasted forty days and forty nights, afterward He was hungry. ³ Now when the tempter came to Him, he said, ‘If You are the Son of God, command that these stones become bread.’ ⁴ But He answered and said, ‘It is written, ‘Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceeds from the mouth of God.’” ⁵ Then the devil took Him up into the holy city, set Him on the pinnacle of the temple, ⁶ and said to Him, “If You are the Son of God, throw Yourself down. For it is written: ‘He shall give His angels charge over you,’ and, ‘In their hands they shall bear you up, Lest you dash your foot*

against a stone.’”⁷ Jesus said to him, “It is written again, ‘You shall not tempt the LORD your God.’”⁸ Again, the devil took Him up on an exceedingly high mountain, and showed Him all the kingdoms of the world and their glory.⁹ And he said to Him, “All these things I will give You if You will fall down and worship me.”¹⁰ Then Jesus said to him, “Away with you, Satan! For it is written, ‘You shall worship the LORD your God, and Him only you shall serve.’”¹¹ Then the devil left Him, and behold, angels came and ministered to Him.”

INTRO: The story of the temptation of Jesus seems to have a strange setting indeed. A baptismal service was being conducted in the Jordan River and John the Baptist was the name of the minister performing the ordinance of water baptism. John was not cut from the cloth of normal priestly protocol quite the contrary is true: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- His message was a departure from the norm - His was a message of repentance.
- His attire was anything but fashionable - A camels skin suit held in place by a leather girdle.
- His diet was shocking - His favorite meal was grasshoppers and wild honey.

Immediately following the baptism of one of the candidates John looked up to see a young man approaching from the distant horizon. As the man drew nearer John recognized the familiar stride of his cousin, Jesus Christ. In his attempt to exchange pleasantries with Jesus, John utters words that would become an historic anomaly and a prophetic benchmark; ***"Behold the lamb of God which taketh away the sins of the world."***

In his declaration of his Cousin Jesus' arrival, John not only declared Jesus to be a

lamb but ***"THE Lamb of God"*** that would ***"TAKE AWAY the sins of the world."***

Upon His baptism, a wonderful phenomenon occurred involving a dove, defying its nature to make physical contact with a human being, and a voice booming from the sky saying, ***"This is my beloved son in whom I am well pleased."***

The really shocking feature of this entire story is what happens next: Jesus is ***"Led of the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil."***

The picture becomes extremely vague over the next forty days but we do know Jesus passed the time fasting and praying and in fellowship with the father. Following this forty-day rendezvous with God, Jesus emerges from His sabbatical only to be met by a direct assault from Satan himself. The

events that follow are commonly referred to as the “*Temptation of Jesus*”.

**THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN
TEMPTATION AND TESTING
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT
SLIDE)**

The “*Temptation of Jesus*” is not what most people have believed it to be. This temptation could probably be better described as the “*Testing of Jesus*”.

A more in-depth look at these two words reveals a Scriptural truth that has been almost totally ignored. **Temptation is always self-inflicted just as testing is allowed by our Heavenly Father for the purpose of: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Strengthening us...
- Building our faith...
- Preparing us for greatness...

- Developing character that can stand the onslaught of success and failure...

On the other hand, temptation as we know it, is the enticement to do evil. The enticement to do evil: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Does not build our faith...
- Does not better prepare us for success or failure...
- Is destructive to our character...

The testing of Jesus consisted of the following: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The lust of the flesh - He had not received nourishment for his body for forty days, and the first thing the enemy attempted to do was entice Him to use His supernatural ability to satisfy the flesh side of His nature. ***“If You are the Son of God, command that these stones***

become bread.” Was He hungry? He was starving!

- **The Lust of the eyes** - Satan tried to entice Jesus to cast himself down from the pinnacle of the temple, thus falling into a trap of using His divine connections and heightened spiritual awareness to do something that would defy natural and divine law. ***“If You are the Son of God, throw Yourself down. For it is written: ‘He shall give His angels charge over you,’ and, ‘In their hands they shall bear you up, Lest you dash your foot against a stone.’”*** In so doing He would have been guilty of using His powers to appeal to the senses. Our Souls consist of our mind, will, and emotions. Unless we properly control our mind, will, and emotions through the power of the Holy Spirit we tend to become more sensual than spiritual. When we allow the sensual to prevail over the spiritual, we are by an act of our

own will stepping outside the protection and provision of God. When we step outside the protection and provision of God we become drawn away of our own lust, caving in to temptation. This is a test of the sensual side of Jesus. The enemy was attempting to entice Him into the spectacular at a time of super spirituality. Jesus understood that if He jumped from the pinnacle of the Temple and Angels carried Him safely to the earth the sensual rush would never satisfy, but leave Him lusting for more. All attempts to satisfy the soul leave the individual lusting for more.

- [The pride of life](#) - Satan continues the test by attempting to appeal to the spiritual side of Jesus by leading Him to a high mountain and telling Him if He would bow down and worship, he would give Him all He could see. ***“Then Jesus said to him, “Away with you, Satan! For it is written, ‘You shall worship the***

LORD your God, and Him only you shall serve.’” The spiritual side of every person is destined to rule as a king and priest. Because we are destined to rule as kings and priests every believer has a natural bent to worship and reign. This can get us into trouble if we worship the wrong things and try to reign over territory we are not called to. Because we have a predisposition for worshipping and reigning many of the tests that come our way will be spiritual in nature. The enemy consistently attempts to keep us from becoming all we can be in the spiritual realm and then uses our lack of perceived progress as a catalyst to convince us to give up on our destiny. Jesus had a leg up on the tempter because he was fully aware that what he was offering was not his to give. This was an illusion as are all the enemy's claims of entitlement or bestowment.

THE VULNERABILITY OF TEMPTATION

**(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT
SLIDE)**

James 1:12-15 (NKJV) *"Blessed is the man who endures temptation; for when he has been approved, he will receive the crown of life which the Lord has promised to those who love Him.13 Let no one say when he is tempted, "I am tempted by God"; for God cannot be tempted by evil, nor does He Himself tempt anyone.14 But each one is tempted when he is drawn away by his own desires and enticed.15 Then, when desire has conceived, it gives birth to sin; and sin, when it is full-grown, brings forth death."*

James 1:12-15 (LB) *"Happy is the man who doesn't give in and do wrong when he is tempted, for afterwards he will get as his reward the crown of life that God has promised those who love him. 13 And remember, when someone wants to do*

wrong it is never God who is tempting him, for God never wants to do wrong and never tempts anyone else to do it. 14 Temptation is the pull of man's own evil thoughts and wishes. 15 These evil thoughts lead to evil actions and afterwards to the death penalty from God."

There are three basic temptations or tests that we all face: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Things God allows - This testing has its limits and our spiritual growth and character have been pre-tested and deemed sufficient for the test. I see no record in Scripture of anyone failing a test that was pre-approved by God. (Job) 1 Corinthians 10:13 (NKJV) *"No temptation has overtaken you except such as is common to man; but God is faithful, who will not allow you to be tempted beyond what you are able, but with the temptation will also make the*

way of escape, that you may be able to bear it."

- [Things Satan designs](#) - God will never sanction a test that allows for a moral failure. The enemy cannot force you to sin; the devil did not make you do it! He can do no more than make a brief presentation of the temptation. (King David)
- [Self-inflicted temptation](#) - By our own volition and imagination we take the bait of Satan and imagine our way into a situation that we are powerless to win (Samson).

Temptation, as we know it, has to do with an enticement to do, that which is in direct moral conflict with Biblical standards and practices. (Lying - stealing - cheating - etc.)

According to the Word, God cannot be tempted by these things and will not authorize such an attack against us! James

1:13-15 (LB) *"And remember, when someone wants to do wrong it is never God who is tempting him, for God never wants to do wrong and never tempts anyone else to do it. 14 Temptation is the pull of man's own evil thoughts and wishes. 15 These evil thoughts lead to evil actions and afterwards to the death penalty from God."*

**THE PROTECTION OF TESTING
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT
SLIDE)**

You are probably thinking that Jesus faced the same temptations we do yet He did not sin. This is true; the Bible states it very vigorously. [Hebrews 4:15](#) (NKJV) *"For we do not have a High Priest who cannot sympathize with our weaknesses, but was in all points tempted as we are, yet without sin."* Hebrews 4:15 (LB) *"This High Priest of ours understands our weaknesses since he had the same temptations we do, though*

he never once gave way to them and sinned."

So what kind of temptation did Jesus face?
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- He was restricted by the limitations of the flesh - He became hungry - Matthew 4 (Turn these stones into bread), this was the first way the enemy tested Him.
- He became physically exhausted - Several times in Scripture He removed Himself from the crowd for some rest and relaxation.
- He became lonely - *"Foxes have holes, birds have nests, but the son of man does not have a place to lay His head."*
- He suffered rejection - The betrayal of Judas. The night prior to the crucifixion Jesus was agonizing in prayer and the disciples could not stay awake with Him for one hour - We can almost hear the

rejection in Jesus' voice as He say's
"Sleep on now."

- He endured conflict within His family – Mary and Joseph looking for Him after He had been gone three days.
- He was tempted to get angry and lose His temper - Dealing with the mercenaries in the Temple.
- He suffered physical pain - His crucifixion.

Though Jesus was tested in many ways, there is not one shred of evidence in the Bible that He was tempted to do anything in conflict with Biblical standards or practices!

Every test we face must meet the approval of God in advance. **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** God looks at the test and then looks at where we are and what we are capable of enduring in the physical, emotional, and spiritual realm. In this process He considers our faith and

endurance and would never allow the enemy to bring anything against us that we are incapable of handling. *"No testing has overtaken you that is not common to everyone. God is faithful, and he will not let you be tested beyond your strength, but with the testing he will also provide the way out so that you may be able to endure it."*

Testing has to do with living in right relationship with God and others regardless of the pressure to do otherwise. **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** Testing also has to do with standing on the promises of God despite the temptation to do otherwise. To the person who is tested by God the highest form of reality is what the Word of God has to say on the subject.

In the testing of Jesus He took three scriptures out of the Old Testament book of Deuteronomy and whipped the devil all over

the desert. I am convinced that God looked at the test and then at His son Jesus and said something like this to an angel; *"This should be good; Satan wants to test Jesus by offering Him food, sensationalism, and power! What a dumb devil, doesn't he know who Jesus is and where He has been?"* By the way, we are also sons of God and have been given the same rights, privileges and power as Jesus had when He was upon the earth.

PRACTICAL APPLICATION

The key to our success in any test we face is as follows: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Live within the hedge of protection God has cast for us. The hedge consists of the Blood of Jesus and the Word of God. As long as we live our lives within those perimeters we have nothing to fear from the enemy. He can't win and we can't lose!

- Never allow the devil to entice us to step outside the Bloodline. We must never allow him to convince us that even though the Word of God speaks out against a certain behavior God will make an exception for us.